

A man with a large, curly afro hairstyle, wearing glasses and a light blue button-down shirt, is smiling and holding a white tablet. The background is a blurred office or indoor setting.

Job aid

**How online
communities
create repeat
customers**

How online communities create repeat customers: Plan of action

Use this plan of action as a living document for creating an online strategy that suits your business needs. The more honest you are in this document, the more effectively you can improve your current online marketing strategy and lock in brand-loyal customers.

Building community online

If you want your small business to grow, it is helpful to build a brand presence in your online community and participate in networking on social media platforms.

Your objective

First things first: Have you defined your brand and your brand goals?

What goals do you hope to accomplish by building your online community?

Purpose

Use the chart below to help craft the purpose of your online community. This should involve your brand mission, company vision, and brand personality.

Questions	Answer/Notes
How well-defined is your company vision? Your brand mission? How could your online community help you reinforce your purpose and what you stand for?	
If you're trying to launch a new online community, ask yourself: What experiences do you want your members to have? How can you help them identify even more with you or your brand?	
If you have an existing online community, ask yourself: What experiences are your community members currently having? How can you improve their experiences or better align them with your purpose?	

Member profile

It is difficult to start a community or put together a marketing campaign if you do not understand your customers’ needs. Start with the people already buying from you, following you, and interacting with your posts. Some data points you might want to consider are included in the chart below for reference.

Take some time to fill in the chart with data you've gathered about your target audience and possible next steps you can take to appeal to them.

Data points and why they matter	Target audience data	Next steps
Interests What does your target audience like to do? What TV shows do they watch? What other businesses do they interact with?		
Challenges What pain points are your audience dealing with?		
Age Focus on learning the general age groups or generational identity of your community members, rather than specific ages.		

Data points and why they matter	Target audience data	Next steps
Location (including time zones) Where do your community members live? This helps you understand which geographic areas to target. You'll also learn which hours are best for your interacting with the community and when you should schedule your ads, posts, etc.		
Language What language does your target audience speak? Don't assume it's your language or that they speak the dominant language of their current physical location. If there are potential communication barriers, how can you address them to better serve your audience's needs?		
Spending power and patterns How much money does your target audience have to spend? How do they approach purchases in your price category? Do they have specific financial concerns or preferences you need to address?		
Stage of life Does your target audience include college students? New parents? Parents of teens? Retirees?		

Setting up your community

Consider your resources. Who can help you monitor your community chats and comments? How often will they engage with the community?

How can you make your community engagement more efficient? Could you invest in a part-time community manager or a management software tool?

How will you schedule your community posts and content creation?

Promoting your community

Use the chart below to consider different platforms.

Platforms	Does your target audience use this platform? (Y/N)	Is your business suited to this platform? (Y/N)	How can you use this platform to promote your community?
Facebook Groups	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Instagram	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	
LinkedIn	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Forum (e.g., Quora)	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Blog sites	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	

Reflection

Now that you have drafted the purpose of your online community, created your member profile, and assessed social media platforms for promoting your business, write down two things you did not know prior to completing this activity.

Glossary

Use this glossary as a guide to review key terms and understand how they show up in the real world.



Definition



Practical use

Online community

Also known as an internet community or virtual community, this is a group of people who have a common interest and communicate with each other about it online using websites, discussion boards, instant messaging, email, etc.

Source: marketbusiness.com

Since online communities deal with social networks, marketing your small business on any of the known social media platforms can benefit your business.

Follower

In social media terms, a follower is someone who has subscribed to an account in order to receive updates.

Source: hubspot.com

While acquiring followers is a goal for most online businesses, acquiring a loyal following should be the ultimate goal, as it yields greater engagement.



Definition



Practical use

Community manager

The liaison between the organization and its audience. Community managers act as the voice, tone, and moderator of the brand through community support, content distribution, and digital engagement.

As your business continues to grow, so will its needs. Recruiting a community manager can be very helpful for making sure your members get the attention and engagement they deserve.

Source: [hubspot.com](https://www.hubspot.com)

Learning community

A group of people who enjoy learning and exchanging information about shared interests.

This community may share learning from both successful and unsuccessful experiences to deepen collective knowledge. Ultimately, a community can help empower (or harm) your small business through word-of-mouth.

Source: blog.disclosure.com

Branded community

A group of people who foster a connection with a particular brand and thus develop relationships with each other around their shared appreciation for that brand.

A branded community can create new customers, as well as build greater interest and loyalty among customers who may not feel completely “bought in” yet.

Source: thebusinessprofessor.com



Definition



Practical use

Brand ambassador

Someone who promotes a brand and its products to their network with the objective of increasing brand awareness and helping drive sales.

Consider promoting one of your most active community members to the role of brand ambassador in order to help increase brand awareness and sales.

Source: optimizely.com

A/B testing

The method of comparing two versions of a webpage or app against each other to determine which one performs better.

As a small business owner, A/B testing might provide insight on your customers' experiences that can help improve their overall experience – as well as your conversion rates.

Source: optimizely.com

Content marketing calendar

A written schedule of when and where you plan to publish upcoming content. Also known as an “editorial calendar,” it can be constructed to meet your teams' specific needs.

Use a content calendar to keep track of your upcoming projects, planned promotional activities, and updates to existing content. It will help you stay organized and plan ahead.

Source: blacklinko.com